

RAILWAYS

India's Great Station Gambit

The Amrit Bharat Station Scheme, one of Indian Railways' major post-Independence projects, creates stations that connect both sides of a city

BY MANISH PANT

24 |

► **AS MANY AS** 1,309 railway stations, 27 states and a planned investment of about ₹25,000 crore for the initial part of the project. In a significant first step towards the execution of the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme, Prime Minister Narendra Modi unveiled the redevelopment of 508 stations on August 7. Pointing out that the identity of the cities was linked to their stations, Modi said, "Over time, these railway stations have now become the heart of the city... Therefore, it is crucial today to transform our railway stations into modern and efficient spaces and ensure the optimum utilisation of railway infrastructure." This infrastructure upgrade, one of the largest of its kind undertaken by the Indian Railways in post-Independent India, entails developing stations as centres for connecting both sides of a city.

The railways, often described as "India's

WHEELS IN MOTION

The Jaipur Junction railway station in Rajasthan. Gross budgetary capex for the railways, often described as 'India's lifeline', has increased to ₹2.40 lakh crore in FY24 from ₹28,174 crore in FY14

lifeline," has seen its gross budgetary capex climb to ₹2.40 lakh crore in FY24 from ₹28,174 crore in FY14. The figure is inclusive of station redevelopment expenses. With good funding and the near absence of major challenges like land acquisition, the world's fifth-largest rail network is looking at completing the brown-field station overhaul at the earliest.

"The foundation stone for 40 other stations has been laid by the PM at different times during his tours. The work will, therefore, be taken up at a fast pace. Master plans for more than 700 other stations are also being readied," Ashwini Vaishnaw, Minister of Railways, said after the launch of the scheme. "There is no requirement for land acquisition as the stations have sufficient land of their own. The redevelopment will be focussed on vertically growing the existing buildings," he added.

These Amrit stations will reflect the country's and city's heritage. For instance, Rajasthan's Jaipur Junction railway station will feature Hawa Mahal and Amer Fort designs and Nagaland's Dimapur Station will feature the unique architecture of the region's 16 ethnic communities. Also, the railways will improve platform seating, waiting areas and provide free Wi-Fi to make train journeys more comfortable.

Railway experts like Jagannarayan Padmanabhan, Senior Director at CRISIL Market Intelligence, believe that installing modern amenities, integrating multiple modes of transportation, and incorporating local culture and architecture into station design will improve passenger travel and attract investment. "The Amrit Bharat Station Scheme is thus an important step towards increasing customer stickiness in using railways as a preferred mode of travel."

The redevelopment train that has just chugged out of the station will have many interesting stops along the way. **BT**

PHOTO BY GETTY IMAGES



@manishpant22